

“And suppose, if you will, that someone breaks those eggs,” asks Chief Executive of War Lavelle Saint-Claire, pointing at the little tin men lined up in battalions on the rolling green papier-mâché hills built atop the war table. Her formal dress was pristine, cerulean, and beneath her paygrade as the Chief Executive of War, one of the highest paying positions in the world.

“Impossible!” cried Lieutenant-General-Commander-AA-8888th Battalion Officer Archimedes Ploink, who was a humble man with not much to his name. “They’re fortified in the hills! Anything tries rolling up, they’ll just get pushed right back down! Those eggs are in their carton, so-to-speak. Safe as a supermarket brand, back when we had regulations.”

“The hills *are* advantageous, Lieutenant-General-Commander, but look at how *exposed* they are. Watch,” and she moved in what looked to be model robots, the kind you’d buy and assemble painstakingly. They were unpainted but lovingly made.

The robot mechs surrounded the hills. Some were short and stout with four legs and rocket launchers affixed to either side; others were bipedal and built in man’s image like Adam and Eve. Others still were large cylinders, like submarines of the land; and one was just a single, large, cube. That one could be opened up like a box. No one talked about what it housed inside. It made these war table discussions difficult.

“When pressure is applied from *all* sides,” Lavelle Saint-Claire explained pedagogically, as if teaching the alphabet to a grade schooler, “eggs *crack*.”

Archimedes didn’t know why, but a bead of sweat ran down his gloriously bald head.

“Well, but of course madam, but surely I accounted for that, didn’t I? This battalion is equipped with a portable electromagnetic pulse dispenser. They’ll have it deployed; mechs won’t be able to get close.”

“Artillery,” said Lavelle, “artillery. A pulse dispenser out in the open will be blown off the face of the planet the way a tumor is plucked from the body of a patient in surgery.

“Though I guess in that case, a tumor being removed is a good thing, isn’t it, Lieutenant-General-Commander?” and as she said this, she leered over the squat man, her face disturbingly similar to an owl’s.

“Y-Yes, of course, CEoW.”

“Listen. Let’s say, you’re lucky. You have the luxury of time and you dig a nice hole to hide your pulse dispenser in, and you can place mirror-sols to protect the unit from artillery. What if,” and she swoops her back around like a pendulum such that her leer was now over the table, “your Battalion was not as large here as it seems?

“What if, one-by-one, it was... say, half the size it is now?” and as she speaks, she collected soldiers in her hands and removed them from the table. The battalion on display suddenly appeared much less mighty.

“Wh-what are you getting at, CEoW? Why would that be the case?” huffed Archimedes. That one bead of sweat had bred into dozens, and his formal wear started to resemble a greasy paper bag.

“I know what you’ve been doing, Lieutenant-General-Commander—or should I say, Mr. Ploink, given the recent stripping of your title.”

“M-My what?!”

“You know, as Chief Executive of War, I am authorized to do *whatever* I deem necessary to support The Great Effort.”

She crept over to the back of the room, where she had her own private lounge, with her own private fridge. She opened it and retrieved a carton of eggs, which she sat on the war table in front of Archimedes.

She opened the carton, and of the dozen slots, only two were filled; two eggs, both brown-shelled, sat directly next to each other.

“What is the difference between these eggs, Mr. Ploink?”

With a look of fear in his eyes Mr. Ploink only gasped for air, and fought back mucus that drained down his throat.

After a moment of apprehensive silence, Lavelle tried another question.

“Which of these eggs would you rather buy, Mr. Ploink?” She narrowed her eyes, and continued.

“Which of these eggs belongs *here*,” and she nestled one of the eggs in the hills, lined up like another soldier in the battalion, “and which of these eggs belongs... *here*.” And she squeezed it in her hands, the yolk dripping from her fingers and onto model trees, where it then continued its molasses-like descent before pooling onto the table.

“Ma’am, madam CEoW,” Archimedes spluttered.

“I don’t know how you pick your eggs, Mr. Ploink, but as for me... I believe the bad ones should be removed from the carton,” and Chief Executive of War Lavelle Saint-Claire reached behind her back.